WEEKLY CASE FILE 001

The Last Course

Estimated solve time 10 to 20 minutes

CASE STATUS: OPEN

Your assignment. Determine who deliberately contaminated lead judge Simone Vale's tasting spoon and concealed her emergency medication. Your accusation must identify the responsible finalist and cite the evidence that proves the case.

Case date	Location	Victim	Incident window
Thursday, September 17, 2026	The Atelier School of Culinary Arts, Chicago	Simone Vale, master instructor	10:36 to 10:46 a.m. CDT

Everything required to solve the case appears in this file. No specialist culinary knowledge is required. All times are Central Daylight Time.

Do not open the sealed solution until you have recorded your accusation.

Incident report

The Atelier's four professional pastry finalists presented anonymous tasting portions for the school's annual apprenticeship examination. Simone Vale was the scheduled lead judge. At 10:46 a.m., immediately after using her red-banded tasting spoon on the first dessert, she developed a severe anaphylactic reaction.

A second judge called emergency services while staff searched the labeled medication compartment beside the prep-kitchen door. Simone's epinephrine auto-injector was missing. Paramedics treated her on arrival, but she died shortly after reaching the hospital.

The auto-injector was found after the kitchen was secured. It had been pushed beneath used linens in the lidded laundry hamper beside the staging pass. Laboratory screening found peanut protein and traces of an unidentified aromatic finishing oil on Simone's tasting spoon. All four desserts, their serving utensils, and the other judges' spoons tested negative for peanut protein.

The four finalists

Finalist	Station	Declared dessert	Reason for scrutiny
Lena Ortiz	1	Pear and rosemary entremet	Admitted tasting another finalist's component during the exam.
Caleb Moss	2	Pistachio and sour cherry gâteau	Argued with Simone after she withdrew an apprenticeship recommendation.
Priya Shah	3	Dark chocolate, coffee, and almond torte	Her plate marker appeared beside the dessert Simone had just tasted.
Nolan Reed	4	Apricot croquant with citrus mousse	Met privately with Simone before the examination about his submitted recipe.

FILE A // EXAM PROTOCOL AND INCIDENT TIMELINE

Compiled from the examination handbook, proctor sheet, and emergency report

Required service procedure

- At 10:30 a.m., each finalist places one anonymous tasting portion on the staging pass under the assigned letter marker.
- At 10:36 a.m., the service proctor places three clean judge kits at the north end of the pass. Simone's kit is identified by a red heat-safe band on the spoon handle.
- From 10:39 to 10:43 a.m., finalists may approach the pass one at a time to add a final garnish. They may not touch a judge kit or another finalist's plate.
- The proctor observes the room from the south prep door. The tall linen hamper blocks her view of the north end of the pass when a finalist stands beside Plate D.

Recorded timeline

Time	Recorded event
8:15	Simone meets privately with Nolan in her office.
9:00	Practical examination begins.
10:30	Four anonymous tasting portions are placed on the staging pass.
10:36	Proctor places the three judge kits at the north end of the pass.
10:39	Lena approaches the pass to add pear crisps.
10:40	Caleb approaches the pass to add cherry gel.
10:41	Priya approaches the pass to add a chocolate sail.
10:42	Nolan approaches the pass to add croquant.
10:44	Judges enter. Simone begins with the plate nearest her kit.
10:46	Simone collapses. Emergency response begins.
11:18	Missing auto-injector is recovered from the laundry hamper.

FILE B // STAGING PASS AND CLOSEOUT RECORD

Proctor sketch made at 10:50 a.m.; not to scale

View from above

North wall	Position 1	Position 2	Position 3	Position 4
Judge kits	Simone / RED	Judge 2 / BLUE	Judge 3 / GREEN	Scorecards
Tasting plates	Plate A	Plate B	Plate C	Plate D
Finalist stations	Station 1 opposite	Station 2 opposite	Station 3 opposite	Station 4 opposite
Nearby fixture	Sink	Shared cooling rack	Score stand	Laundry hamper

The south prep door is beyond Plate D. The laundry hamper stands between the proctor at that door and the red-banded judge kit. All four finalists could reach the kit during their authorized garnish turn, but a person standing at Plate D would have the longest obstruction from the proctor's view.

Closeout observations

Item	Location at 10:50	Observation
Red-banded spoon	Simone's place at pass	Peanut protein and an unidentified aromatic oil detected on bowl and underside of handle.
Other judge spoons	Pass	No peanut protein detected.
Four desserts	Secured plates	No peanut protein detected on any sample.
Disposable transfer pipette	Station 2 waste caddy	Peanut protein and the same unidentified aromatic oil detected inside barrel.
Epinephrine auto-injector	Laundry hamper	Operational; no usable fingerprints recovered.
Linen hamper lid	Beside Plate D	Wiped surface; no usable fingerprints recovered.

Note: Waste caddies are movable and are emptied only after all stations have been photographed. An item found in a station's caddy was not necessarily discarded by that station's finalist.

FILE C // INGREDIENT AND PROPERTY CONTROL

Prepared by examination proctor Mae Chen

School-issued finishing liquids

Code	Item	Assigned station	Issue status	Return status
F-11	Rosemary extract	1	Issued 9:04	Returned open; 8 mL used
F-19	Cherry concentrate	2	Issued 9:06	Returned open; 14 mL used
F-24	Coffee extract	3	Issued 9:05	Returned open; 11 mL used
F-17	Orange-blossom finishing oil	4	Issued 9:03	Returned sealed; tamper ring intact

Personal property inspection

Finalist	Declared personal item	Inbound weight	Outbound weight	Difference
Lena	Knife roll and thermometer	1,824 g	1,824 g	0 g
Caleb	Knife roll and offset spatula	1,611 g	1,611 g	0 g
Priya	Knife roll and acetate collars	1,493 g	1,493 g	0 g
Nolan	Knife roll and sugar décor carrier	2,046 g	1,998 g	48 g less

Inspection note: Personal carriers were opened and weighed in the finalist's presence before and after the examination. Nolan attributed the 48-gram difference to broken sugar décor discarded during service. No broken croquant or sugar fragments were documented in any waste caddy.

Ingredient screening

Sample	Peanut protein	Orange-blossom marker
School ingredient containers	Not detected	Detected only in sealed bottle F-17
All four plated desserts	Not detected	Detected on Nolan's dessert as declared
Red-banded spoon residue	Detected	Detected
Station 2 waste-caddy pipette	Detected	Detected

FILE D // CLOSEOUT PHOTOGRAPHS AND UTENSIL ISSUE RECORD

Images transcribed into written observations for accessibility

Photograph 1: stations at 10:37 a.m.

- Station 1: pear crisps on a metal tray; blue-handled detail brush B-11 beside the tray.
- Station 2: cherry gel bottle beside a green-handled detail brush B-09; waste caddy beneath the left edge of the station.
- Station 3: chocolate sail on acetate; no detail brush or transfer pipette visible.
- Station 4: three intact croquant pieces inside the open sugar décor carrier; a narrow clean channel is visible in the orange dust lining the carrier's right side.

Photograph 2: pass and stations at 10:50 a.m.

- The Station 2 waste caddy is now beneath the shared cooling rack, within reach of Stations 2, 3, and 4.
- A clear transfer pipette lies on top of the Station 2 waste. It is not covered by any of Caleb's cherry-stained towels or parchment scraps.
- Station 4's carrier still contains three intact croquant pieces. The narrow channel in its orange dust is empty and measures approximately 11 centimeters long and 2 centimeters wide.
- The sealed school bottle F-17 sits at Station 4 with its tamper ring intact.

Utensil issue record

Item	Issued to	Closeout
Detail brush B-11, blue	Lena	Returned at Station 1
Detail brush B-09, green	Caleb	Returned at Station 2
Transfer pipettes, box of 20	Shared cooling rack	19 unused in box; 1 recovered from Station 2 waste caddy
Offset spatula	Priya	Returned at Station 3
Stainless-steel saucepan	Nolan	Returned at Station 4
Copper saucier	Not issued	Remained locked in equipment cabinet

The clean channel in Nolan's carrier is consistent with a small cylindrical bottle or vial having been removed. The photograph does not establish what the missing object contained.

FILE E // STATEMENTS AND RECOVERED CORRESPONDENCE

Statements taken separately at 12:05 p.m.

Lena Ortiz

“I went to the pass only for my pear crisps. Earlier I used my detail brush to taste Caleb's cherry gel. I knew that broke the rules, so I washed the brush and did not mention it at first. I never touched a judge's spoon or the laundry hamper.”

Caleb Moss

“I added the cherry gel and moved my waste caddy toward the cooling rack because it blocked my knees. Simone and I argued last week, but the recommendation was already gone. At the pass, I used tongs to straighten the red spoon because its handle was hanging over the edge. I did not touch it with my hands.”

Priya Shah

“I placed my chocolate sail and picked up the scorecards when they started sliding. My marker was beside the first dessert after the emergency, but that was where it had been all morning. I did not use a pipette. My almond ingredient was sealed and remained at my station.”

Nolan Reed

“I added my croquant at 10:42 and returned directly to Station 4. I used the school-issued orange-blossom oil in my dessert around 10:12 and returned the empty bottle at closeout. The broken décor in my carrier accounts for the weight loss. I never used a transfer pipette or went near the laundry hamper.”

Email recovered from Simone's account

Sent	From	To	Message
Sept. 16, 8:47 p.m.	Simone Vale	Nolan Reed	Meet me in my office at 8:15 tomorrow. Your submitted croquant formula matches Luc Moreau's unpublished apprenticeship workbook, including the erroneous 18-gram salt entry. We will discuss authorship before judging.

Office calendar note, entered by Simone at 8:32 a.m.: “N.R. denies copying. Notify Moreau and apprenticeship committee after examination.”

Accusation report

Record your conclusion before opening the sealed solution.

1 Who contaminated Simone's tasting spoon

_____

2 What evidence identifies the source of the contaminant

_____
_____

3 Which statement is demonstrably false

_____
_____

4 Why does the pipette in Station 2's waste caddy not prove Caleb used it

_____
_____

5 What was the motive

_____
_____

CASE STATUS: AWAITING YOUR ACCUSATION